9 MILLION Number of Indians living in the Middle East

DIASPORA

WAIT, WATCH, WORRY

As war disrupts trade and travel routes in West Asia, India's vast diaspora trickles back home, threatened by stalled shipments and falling salaries

By JUMANA SHAH

A day before the surprise US-Israel attack on Iran kicked off a war spiralling into chaos, Dubai-based trader Anish Tiwari sold top-of-the-line security devices to a customer in South Africa, with great expectations. A sum of Rs 2 crore was to land in his bank account on March 2, but by then, with the skies above full of warplanes and drones, business deals had little chance of success. The next day, a shipment of his, worth Rs 15 crore, paused on the high seas as the Strait of Hormuz closed and insurance agencies withdrew cover.

A fortnight later, with the conflict showing no signs of abating, he decided enough was enough. Tiwari bought a one-way ticket to India, and plans to return only when the Strait reopens. "Life for civilians is normal in the UAE, but the uncertainty is detrimental for business," he says. He is still one of the privileged ones. White-collar workers like him are largely insulated from the turbulence of war, but two-thirds of the Indian diaspora in the Middle East—numbering some six million—are working lower-paying jobs in construction, logistics, travel and hospitality. In the past month, the Indian Government has repeatedly said that, alongside domestic gas supply, their well-being is the country's top priority.



ANI

SAFE RETURN Noor Rahman Sheikh, Indian ambassador to Lebanon, with Indian nationals departing for Delhi, Beirut, Mar. 11

What is being done

India is among the top three suppliers of the global seafaring workforce, contributing some 13 per cent. An estimated 23,000 Indian seafarers have been impacted in the current crisis. The government of India has started a 24/7 helpline for all seafarers, irrespective of nationality. A dedicated control room and quick response team was instituted this month.

In Parliament, PM Narendra Modi recently said 375,000 Indians have returned from the Middle East since the war began. Saudi Arabia is a node